films in the 1950s, most of them hits or superhits, their pairing lasted till the late 1970s and is called the Suchitra-Uttam yug (era) in this book.

This rich academic study explores a vast range of sources for how the 'star texts' of these two icons were formed—their films, detailed analyses of scenes, but also their off-screen behaviour, public responses to them, archival magazines, gossip, as well as the continued making of their legend after retirement and death. It studies how the modern Bengali bhadralok imagined themselves through these stars, not just via the fandom but also via the censorious responses of the public, critics and the 'art film' circuit.

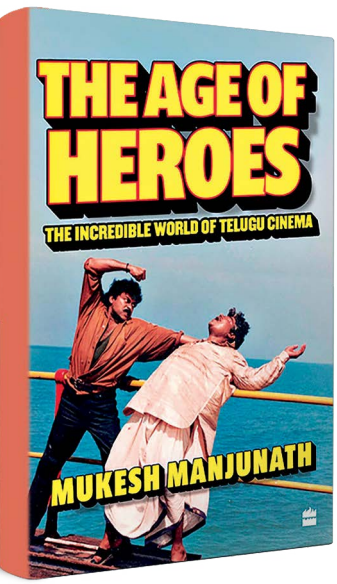
Suchitra-Uttam (she asked for and got top billing in their films) brought in a fresh, liberating energy to the screen; just watch *Saptapadi*'s 'Ei poth jodi' with the luminous pair on a motorbike. Their characters were often urban middle-class doctors, medical students, teachers, architects and such aspirational professions. They depicted ethical love but also delivered a new kind of erotic charge. Though they were married to other people, publicity hinted at their romance with phrases like 'Suchitra-Uttam Leela' and 'Ugr Pranay' (aggressive love).

Even as the stars were objects of desire for their fandom, the anxieties of the bhadralok were played out on their films, especially on the body of Suchitra Sen via discussions of her onscreen "excesses", glamour, willingness to be photographed in daring poses (with 'no kiss' written on her face!), or what was perceived as her disproportionate remuneration. Responses to their onscreen physical intimacy ("lustful expressions" in *Sagarika*, "cheap sex appeal", "commercialisation") were all directed at the actress. This is not how a bhadramahila would behave!

The book also examines some of Sen's films as 'the lonely bhadramahila' (*Saat Pake Bandha*, *Uttar Phalguni*), and Uttam's roles as the elder-brother figure of Bengal (*Jadu Bangsha*, *Nagar Darpane*). In the background of the turbulent Naxal years, his films depicted the grave figure of Uttam grappling with the anger and frustration of Bengali youth that was no longer 'bhadra' in its expression. 'Afterlives' deals with how the stardom of Suchitra and Uttam continues to be cultivated via biographies, exhibitions, television... and offers a critical examination of nostalgia. The image of Suchitra Sen as a Garbo-like recluse, a *sadhika* (god-loving renunciate), a *bandhobi* (friend) placing a garland on Uttam's dead body, lives on. Even as I write this, a new release, *Oti Uttam*, centres itself around the star, integrating shots from 56 old films. The yug has not quite ended. ■

–Juhi Saklani

SUCHITRA AND UTTAM WERE OBJECTS OF DESIRE, BUT BHADRALOK ANXIETIES WERE PLAYED OUT ON THEIR FILMS AND ON THE BODY OF SUCHITRA



THE AGE OF HEROES: The Incredible World of Telugu Cinema
by Mukesh Manjunath
HARPERCOLLINS
₹399; 208 pages

is an illuminating chapter about the "female hero" Vijayashanthi, and a fascinating section about Erra or Red Cinema and its founding deity R. Narayana Murthy—films with protagonists from historically oppressed castes. He also discusses the much-criticised film *Arjun Reddy* in terms that may not be immediately clear to a non-Telugu viewer—the star Vijay Deverakonda's using the Telangana accent "like a sword", bringing coolness and legitimacy to a dialect that was once seen as impure.

Early on, Manjunath clarifies that this book isn't just for those who know Telugu cinema and culture well. This reviewer was glad for his familiarity with some films discussed here—such as the brilliant 1951 fantasy *Pathala Bhairavi*—but learnt much about the subtexts surrounding those films, and what they meant to the local culture, e.g., how a villain is shown to be an outsider through distorted pronunciations. *The Age of Heroes* was completed in 2019, which makes the contemporary references feel dated (*RRR* is referred to as an upcoming film). But this is offset by the fact that the writing is funny in a wry, conversational way. This warm and informative book can open new windows for film buffs hoping to broaden their understanding of the many worlds that exist under the umbrella term "Indian cinema". ■

–Jai Arjun Singh